

FACTORS INFLUENCING SCHOOL DROPOUT IN INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES: A STUDY WITH AN INTERCULTURAL APPROACH.

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INTRODUCTION



Education is a fundamental human right and an indispensable pillar of individual and community development. However, marked Significant inequalities continue to exist in Mexico, hindering both student access and retention, especially in areas with a high Indigenous population, as noted by INEE (2019) and UNESCO (2020). While not concentrated on local contexts, those reports indicate that factors such as poverty, lack of basic services,

discrimination, and the limited cultural relevance of educational programs can increase the risk of students dropping out of school at various educational levels. This research rigorously examines the factors influencing university retention among Indigenous students in Tanquian de Escobedo, Mexico, with the goal of providing a comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon from social and pedagogical perspectives. To explore this issue in depth, it is necessary to consider these students' experiences from an intersectional perspective. On the economic level, limitations in covering transportation, food, academic materials, and living expenses constitute persistent obstacles that threaten completion and attainment. In the academic sphere, educational gaps are identified due to unequal prior preparation and a lack of contextualised tutoring and pedagogical strategies that address students' cultural diversity. From a sociocultural perspective, retention is influenced by family and community responsibilities. In this context, the municipality of Tanquián de Escobedo, San Luis Potosí, Mexico, and the Intercultural University of San Luis Potosí, Tanquián campus, constitute a relevant setting for studying higher education dropout rates due to their geographic, cultural, and socioeconomic characteristics.

METHODOLOGY

This study uses a quantitative and descriptive approach, With an exploratory focus, to understand the socioeconomic, family, and academic conditions that influence university student dropout. The quantitative approach allows for measuring the magnitude of the identified risk factors using structured instruments, while the descriptive component allows for characterizing students' living conditions and perceptions of their academic retention. Furthermore, the research adopts a cross-sectional design, as the data were collected over a specific period without longitudinal follow-up, which provides a general overview of the situation at the time of the study. The study population consisted of all students enrolled at the Intercultural University of San Luis Potosí, Tanquián Campus, during the semester in which the research was conducted. To ensure representativeness and coverage of different academic programs and educational levels, a non-probability convenience sampling was. used, The survey consisted of 25 items organized into four thematic sections related to the factors influencing school dropout among Indigenous students. The first section collected sociodemographic information such as age, gender, indigenous language, and family socioeconomic status. The second section addressed academic factors including school performance, teacher–student relationships, access to learning materials, and academic motivation. The third section focused on sociocultural aspects such as family support, community expectations, and cultural identity. Finally, the fourth section examined technological and infrastructural factors, such as internet access, availability of electronic devices, transportation, and school facilities. All items were rated on a five-point Likert scale ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree. The sample size was 209 students, sufficient to conduct descriptive and comparative statistical analyses of socioeconomic, academic, and family variables. The sample composition considered diversity in terms of gender, age, geographic origin, and educational background, with the aim of accurately reflecting the diverse student population.



TECHNOLOGICAL REFLECTIONS

The findings reveal that many students face challenging family circumstances, work obligations, and health-related issues that limit their study time and affect their academic performance. From a technological perspective, these results highlight the importance of integrating digital solutions that support students in managing these difficulties. Access to flexible online learning platforms, virtual tutoring, and digital academic resources could enable students to balance their studies with their family and work responsibilities. In this regard, technology becomes an essential ally in promoting inclusion, academic retention, and equal opportunities, especially for Indigenous students in rural areas, where educational and economic challenges are more pronounced.

RELEVANT LITERATURE

School dropout rates in higher education are a serious issue that highlights inequalities, especially in Indigenous and rural communities. From this perspective, it is crucial to understand that dropping out is not just an individual choice; it is influenced by a number of social, economic, and family factors, as noted by Tuirán (2001). Latapí (2009) points out significant gaps in the Mexican education system. Urban and rural students have different levels of access, retention, and completion rates. According to data from the Secretariat of Public Education of Mexico (2021), only 18% of Indigenous youth can pursue higher education, compared with 39% of non-Indigenous youth. This difference reveals the barriers young people from marginalised communities face, underscoring the need to address these inequalities. Research by Díaz and Rojas (2018) identifies key challenges for Indigenous students, including a lack of financial support and transportation issues. These problems disrupt their education and hurt their self-confidence and sense of belonging in university. By focusing on these barriers, we can start important conversations about how to understand and fix educational inequalities. We must work together to ensure that every young person has the opportunity to finish their education and succeed.

RESULTS

Family Context

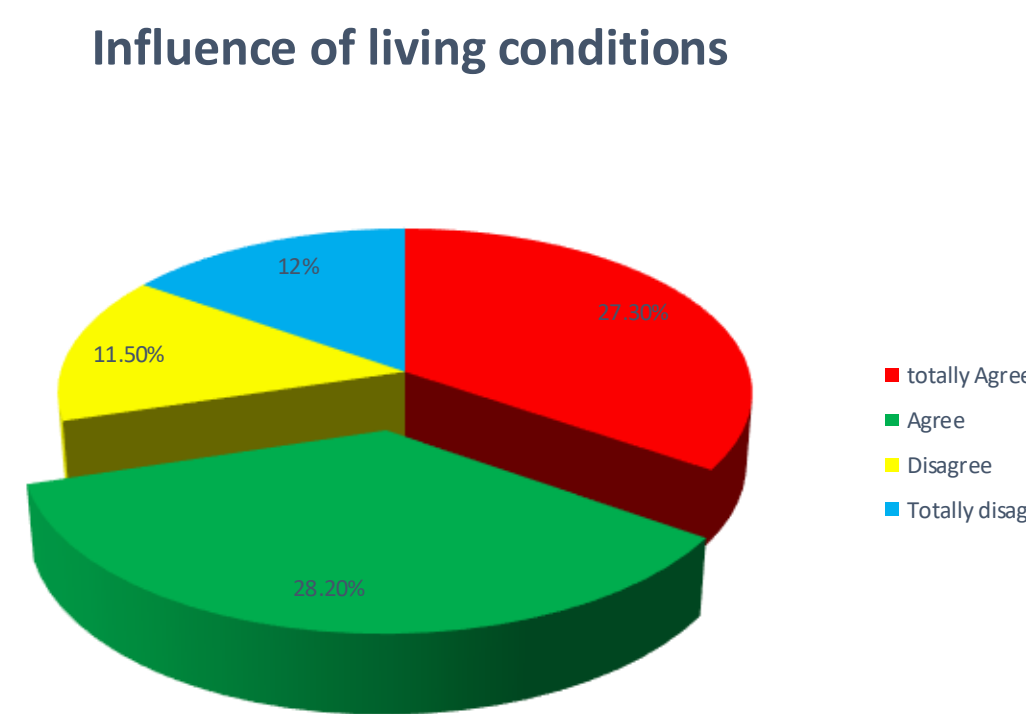
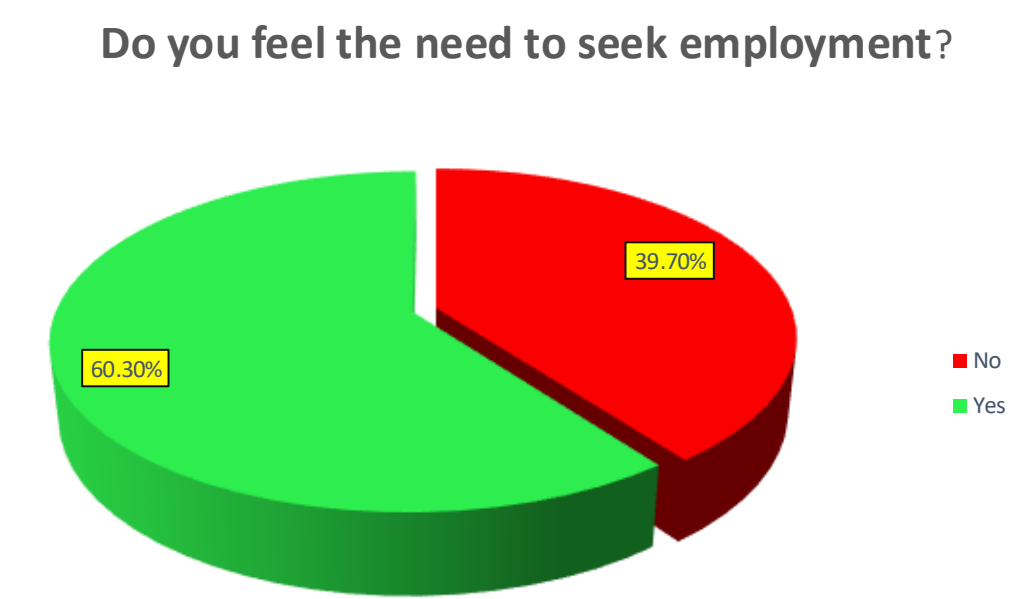
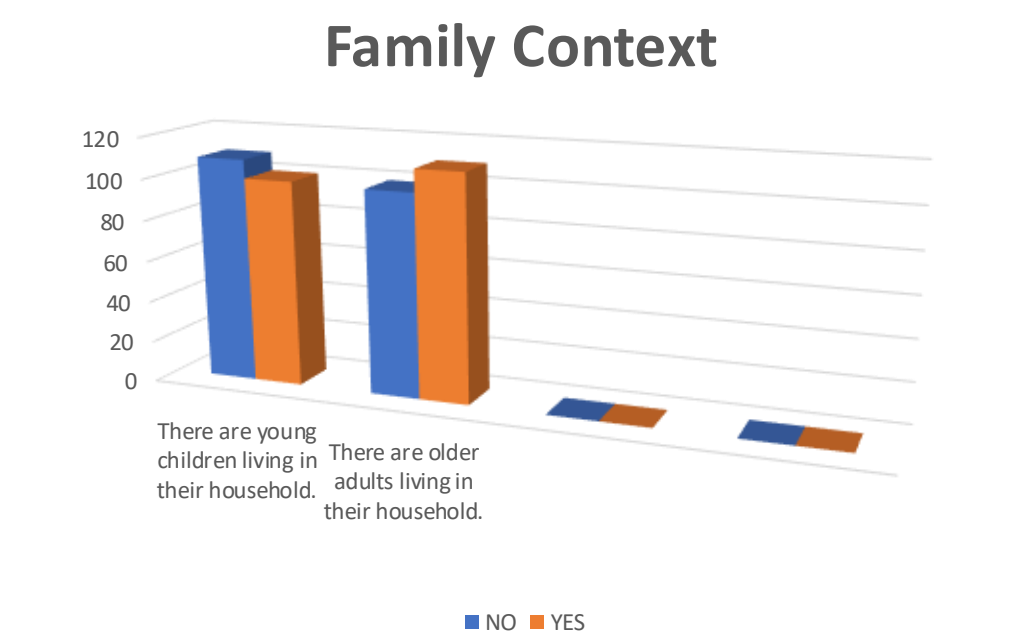
Of the total respondents, 47.4% live with older adults and 52.6% live with young children; it is worth noting that some students may live with both groups simultaneously, with 54 students reporting living with both. Consequently, living with family members in these contexts does influence students' time availability and the pressures they face, which can affect their academic performance and potentially increase the risk of school dropout.

The need to work

The results show that 60.3% of the surveyed students indicated that they feel the need to seek employment, while 39.7% do not. Furthermore, in response to the question "Are you currently working?," 42.6% of students answered "yes," while 57.4% answered "no." These findings suggest that a considerable number of students combine their studies with work activities, which may represent an additional challenge for continuing their university education.

Influence of Living Conditions

The results show that 21.1% of students "strongly agree" and 28.2% "agree" that their health may influence their decision to continue studying. Additionally, 27.3% reported being "neither agree nor disagree," while only 11.5% disagreed and 12% strongly disagreed. These data indicate that more than half of the student population consider health as a factor in their academic persistence. Although our data do not directly measure dropout risk, the literature suggests that these socioeconomic factors may increase the likelihood of students discontinuing their studies.



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